

The Water Cycle

A simple guide to how water moves through nature

What Is the Water Cycle?

The water cycle, also called the hydrologic cycle, describes the continuous movement of water on, above, and below the surface of the Earth. Water is always changing states between liquid, vapor, and ice, and this cycle has no true starting or ending point — it simply keeps repeating.

The Main Stages

1. Evaporation

The sun heats water in oceans, rivers, and lakes, turning it into water vapor that rises into the atmosphere.

2. Condensation

As water vapor rises and cools, it changes back into tiny liquid droplets, forming clouds.

3. Precipitation

When droplets in clouds combine and become heavy enough, they fall back to Earth as rain, snow, sleet, or hail.

4. Collection

Fallen water gathers in oceans, lakes, and rivers, or soaks into the ground as groundwater, ready to evaporate again and restart the cycle.

Why It Matters

- It supplies fresh water to plants, animals, and humans.
- It helps regulate Earth's climate and weather patterns.
- It shapes landscapes through erosion and sediment transport.
- It supports ecosystems by cycling nutrients through water.

In short, the water cycle is nature's way of recycling one of the most essential resources on our planet, keeping it in constant, balanced motion.